Kerala has the highest literacy ratio (94%), Mizoram (91.3%),followed by Goa (88.7%), Himachal Pradesh (82.8%), Maharastra (82.3%),Sikkim (81.4%), and Tamil Nadu (80.1%). Bihar has the lowest literacy ratio (61.8%) in 2011.

7.4 Natural Resources

Any stock or reserve that can be drawn from nature is a Natural Resource. The major natural resources are - land, forest, water, mineral and energy. India is rich in natural resources, but majority of the Indians are poor. Nature has provided India with diverse climate, several rivers for irrigation and power generation, rich minerals, rich forest and diverse soil.

Types of Natural resources

(a) Renewable Resources: Resources that can be regenerated in a given span of time. E.g. forests, wildlife, wind, biomass, tidal, hydro energies etc.

(b) Non-Renewable Resources: Resources that cannot be regenerated. E.g. Fossil fuels-coal, petroleum, minerals, etc.

7.4.1 Land Resources

In terms of area India ranks seventh in the world with a total area of 32.8 lakh sq. km. It accounts for 2.42% of total area of the world. In absolute terms India is really a big country. However, land- man ratio is not favourable because of the huge population size.

According to Agricultural Census, the area operated by large holdings (10 hectares and above) has declined and area operated under marginal holdings (less than one hectare) has increased. This indicates that land is being fragmented and has become uneconomic.

7.4.2 Forest Resources

India's forest cover in 2007 is 69.09 million hectare which constitutes 21.02 per cent of the total geographical area. Of this, 8.35 million hectare is very dense forest, 31.90 million hectare is moderately dense forest and the rest 28.84 million hectare is open forest.

7.4.3 Important Mineral Resources

a. Iron-Ore

India possesses high quality iron-ore in abundance. The total reserves of iron-ore in the country are about 14.630 million tonnes of haematite and 10,619 million tonnes of magnetite. Hematite iron is mainly found in Chattisgarh, Jharkhand, Odisha, Goa and Karnataka.The major deposit of magnetite iron is available at western coast of Karnataka. Some deposits of iron ore are also found in Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh.

b. Coal and Lignite

Coal is the largest available mineral resource. India ranks third in the world after China and USA in coal production. The main centres of coal in India are West Bengal, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra,Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. Bulk of the coal production comes from Bengal-Jharkhand coalfields.

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